

APPLYING PROBLEM-SOLVING TO INTERPERSONAL CONFLICT

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Accept responsibility for attempting to find mutually agreeable constructive solutions to conflicts.
2. Brainstorm solutions and analyze their advantages and disadvantages.
3. Implement solutions that are designed to produce “win-win” outcomes.
4. Evaluate the implemented solution as to its degree of mutual acceptance and satisfaction.

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE MOST USEFUL

- Anger Management
- Antisocial Behavior
- Intimate Relationship Conflicts
- Phase of Life Problems
- Vocational Stress

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

Many clients need to learn problem-solving skills because they see no solution to problems other than anger, withdrawal, or aggression. This exercise is designed to help the client use classical problem-solving skills to find “win-win” solutions to conflicts with friends, family members, coworkers, spouse, or supervisor. The client may need considerable assistance in completing this assignment since the habit of using dysfunctional problem-solving approaches may be deeply engrained and learned in childhood.

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Getting along with others requires the ability to negotiate solutions to disagreements. All relationships have times of conflict. It is most important that disagreements not trigger immediate anger and withdrawal. A much better reaction to conflict is to seek to find a resolution to which both sides agree. This is called a “win-win” situation and results in both parties being satisfied. A conflict that leads to immediate aggression yields a “win-lose” situation and results in hurt, resentment, and anger. This exercise is designed to help you apply problem-solving skills to current conflicts in your life to produce a “win-win” result.

1. Describe a problem of conflict between yourself and the other party in as much detail as possible.

2. Brainstorm all the possible solutions to the problem that you can think of and list them on the following lines.

3. Pick two or three of the most reasonable and fair solutions from your brainstorm list and list the advantages and disadvantages of each solution.

Solution #1: _____

Advantages

Disadvantages

Solution #2: _____

Advantages

Disadvantages

Solution #3: _____

Advantages

Disadvantages

4. Select and write down the best solution option that is apparent from your advantages and disadvantages analysis.

5. Indicate when and where you will begin to implement the solution you have selected.

6. After the solution has been implemented, evaluate the outcome of this effort.

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7. What changes need to be made in the conflict solution that you selected for it to be even more effective?
